months of talks the two of them did manage to hammer out a truce. Its details were fixed mid-river. Ali Quli and Munim Khan met on the Ganga, at Buxar. Behind each of them, the riverbanks were teeming with soldiers, prepared to attack at a moment's notice.[48] Ali Quli clambered into Munim's boat, they embraced, tears were shed and promises made – and over two days of banquets and negotiations, it was decided that both sides would suspend hostilities, and that Ali Quli would send his mother and his uncle, Ibrahim, to Akbar's court, as sureties for Ali Quli's submission.

Again, Akbar agreed, stipulating only that Ali Quli stay on his side of the river as long as Akbar remained in the east.

Only 100-odd kilometres away, in Sarwar, Ali Quli's brother Bahadur's rebellion was proceeding in a very different way. While Munim could build peace on the scaffolding of his old friendship with Ali Quli, the commander pursuing Bahadur, Mir Muizzulmulk, had no such affection for Ali Quli's brother. Muizzulmulk refused all attempts to negotiate, declaring that the Uzbeks' crimes could only be washed away 'by the bloody deluge of the shining sword'.[49] He was greatly encouraged, it seems, by Todar Mal – the 'oil of naphtha' on Muizzulmulk's ire.[50]

As it happens, however, the commander's anger exceeded his ability: Bahadur won the battle between them; and followed his victory with a daring raid on Jaunpur – 'throwing up a noose, [he] climbed into the fortress'[51] – to rescue his and Ali Quli's mother, so recently made guarantee of her sons' good behaviour. Not to be outdone, Ali Quli broke the pact that required him to stay on his side of the Ganga while Akbar toured the east.

Akbar was enraged. He even threatened to move his capital from Agra to Jaunpur until the Uzbeks came to heel. At this, Ali Quli sent renewed pleas for peace – and his newly rescued mother, back again – to Munim; and, once again, the Uzbek's friends in Akbar's court persuaded the padishah to give him another chance.[52]

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Akbar returned to Agra, and Ali Quli to his rebellion. The Uzbek may have made a show of repentance to get Akbar to leave, but he had no intention of letting the boy win. He was damned, in fact, if a so-called padishah with only a battle against villagers in Paronkh to his name would tell him,